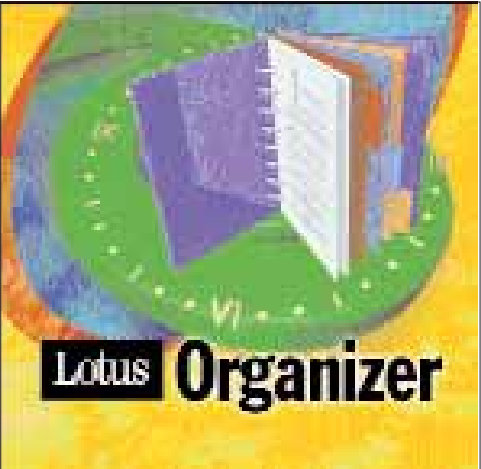


with a user-friendly interface and adequate help and documentation scored brownie points over others. And of course, the price of the software was compared with the functionality to determine whether it was worth spending money on. The overall score was based on three parameters—features, ease of use and price. All three were given equal weightage.

Scheduler

A scheduler is one of the most important features in a PIM. It helps you plan your day and keep track of which tasks need to be completed and by when. A good scheduler used well can streamline work and make life easier. The schedulers of most of the PIMs were feature-filled, although many failed to make use of their interface to show off their various features. Lotus Organizer was good in this respect. It has a user-friendly feel with an interface that looks like a diary and is really convenient if you plan to use your PIM for scheduling work and tasks throughout the day. Microsoft Outlook was better. It comes with a sleek looking calendar that has views of the current and future months. To add or edit tasks, simply click on the date to view the time-slots of the entire day, along with those of that particular month. Selecting a particular time opens up a window that allows you to do a range of things, such as setting a reminder alarm or scheduling work with your other mates. RedBox Organizer follows in the path of these two, although its scheduler isn't as detailed as that of Microsoft Outlook. Corel, on the other hand, has a simple scheduler with basic functions, which makes it good for home users who don't need too much of customisation and features packed into their PIM.

Day Timer's Scheduler isn't as feature-packed as Microsoft Outlook, and the interface isn't too interesting either. Also, everything has to be done manually by going to menus and selecting



Lotus Organizer: Good feature-set

options to activate features. So when it comes to schedulers, **Microsoft Outlook** and **RedBox Organizer** come out tops. Lotus Organizer is great too but a little bit of additional features would be welcome.

Reminders

Just like a secretary reminds the boss about important appointments and other meetings, reminders ring an alarm or send an alert to tell you when you need to do a particular task.

With Microsoft Outlook, you can set alerts that pop up at a particular time. Or you can use reminder notes that can be dragged and dropped into any other application. In RedBox, the reminders section allows you to get a bird's eye view of the reminders and alerts when you load the program onto the main menu. Lotus Organizer's reminder can be set by double-clicking on a particular time in the scheduler, which in turn brings up a whole lot of other features. At the other end of the spectrum are software like Cute Organizer and Epoch Organizer, which have not concentrated on this feature.

Microsoft Outlook once again wins first place. It allows you to set time, along with other customisable features, while the others have a simple alert option that you can set on your PC.

Address Book

To be able to use the PIM to the fullest, you should be able to keep a database of your contacts within it. If you want to call a particular contact, or e-mail him, you should be able to start the particular application such as a phone dialler or a mail client just by clicking on the name. Sorting and categorising should also be available in a good PIM. If groups can be made and mailing lists can be created, that's another plus point.

The address book feature has been well created and integrated into Microsoft Outlook. You can simply sit down and add a whole list of entries as standalone contacts, or you can also set up a small mailing or distribution list that contains a list of people. The contacts are listed alphabetically. A large number of other details can be added besides the individual's contact information. You can switch from one view to another by clicking on the various tabs. Filtering and sorting of contacts is also possible by right-clicking, which brings down the menu that



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